

The following oral history interview is the result of 1 videorecorded session of an interview with Kat Stephens by Cynthia Tobar on February 5, 2018 in New York City. This interview is part of the Black Live Matter in Higher Education oral history project. Kat Stephens has reviewed the transcript and has made minor corrections and emendations. The reader is asked to bear in mind that they/she/he is reading a verbatim transcript of the spoken word, rather than written prose.

Kat Stephens

[Start of recorded material 00:00:01]

Kat Stephens: [00:00:01] So my name is Kat Stephens and I am an EDM student in the higher Ed program.

Cynthia Tobar: What is your background?

Kat Stephens: [00:00:10] Sure, so early life started for me in South America where I was born. So I was born in Guyana in South America and so my family came to the United States when I was a small child. We moved to Queens – actually we moved to Queens first and then we moved to Brooklyn and then we moved back to Queens. So a lot of my childhood was spent in the five boroughs; it's pretty much all I know, New York City all the time, every day, all day. I'm the youngest of six girls between my parents and I just have a very traditional immigrant upbringing. Went to school, came home, studied, wash and repeat.

Cynthia Tobar: What was growing up in New York City like at that time?

Kat Stephens: [00:00:51] That was in the '80s and '90s and so my childhood – we lived in – when we lived in Brooklyn it was at the height of like [unintelligible] and drugs happening everywhere and violence and so our parents did a really good job of insulating us from what was going on outside. We were very sheltered, very protected, but when we went outside we knew how to carry ourselves so that we didn't get caught up what was going on.

[00:01:16] When we first came to the country we lived in the projects and so that was a different understanding when we were – back home in my country we were not – we didn't have projects there so it was a very different shift, cultural shift so I think for me it kind of helped me to be bicultural in a way.

Cynthia Tobar: What was your educational experience like?

Kat Stephens: [00:01:38] So my formative schooling has been here in the United States because I was the youngest and so when we came here I wasn't in school. I started school in America. However, I do have memories of school trips. I have memories of having nontraditional lunches and things being wrapped up, like roti and curry and like, you know, oxtail and things like that being wrapped up in foil paper, and I didn't have like a ham and cheese sandwich.

[00:02:06] That was not what I went to school with. I remember being made fun of because curry is curry and it has a smell and it can stain your fingers. Now I look back at it fondly but I think as a child like you don't want to be different, you want to be the same as everyone else.

[00:02:23] There was a high importance placed on education in my childhood. It was what we knew and what we were set up to do and set up to do really well. That was what we understood; that we had to do that.

Cynthia Tobar: Who made that understanding clear for you while you were growing up?

Kat Stephens: [00:02:38] My mother was well read herself. Both her and my father do not – have not gone to college. They didn't earn their college degrees and so they came here and earned their GEDs. So my mother was very well read, always grew up reading the most, reading the best, always new things.

[00:02:59] I followed her along when she enrolled in community college for a little bit at Kingsborough Community College in Brooklyn. She enrolled there for a little bit. I remember being a child and following her to class and like reading her textbooks when I was in first or second grade.

Cynthia Tobar: Could you elaborate on your mother's experience pursuing higher education in the States?

Kat Stephens: [00:03:18] I remember reading about death and dying, which is a very odd thing, but I remember reading her books for that class. I don't know why that stood out to me. We were at the kitchen table. We would look at her books and I think she went to school maybe – two semesters maybe; she didn't go for long but she worked a lot as a home health aide and so she had a lot of clients that she would go and help them when they were ill and she would take care of them and monitor them, the elderly, so that was what she ended up having to do.

[00:03:50] So school was not something that she was able to continue to pursue, but we had school at home. We had school at home. We watched – there was a lot of cultural education, cultural things also. My mother always had books so we always had books. When I was a child I read the encyclopedia for fun, I read the dictionary for fun. It was really strange but it was really fun.

Cynthia Tobar: What got you interested in going to college?

Kat Stephens: [00:04:17] I don't think I had a choice in going to college. I think the idea was something that we knew; that I personally knew was going to happen. I don't know how it was going to happen. We didn't have like a set of people – we

didn't have a lot of people who had done it before us but I knew college was going to happen, particularly being in the United States.

[00:04:38] The only college that we had known of, that I had known of growing up was the CUNY system being in New York City and so I knew that that was going to be it but I wanted to step out of that and so I had applied to a bunch of different schools. I wanted to go away.

[00:04:53] I remember seeing a different world and like all of that, so the college should be a different world and thinking I want to go to Howard or I want to go Spelman. And so I aspired to that but also knowing it was highly unlikely because of the cost and because no one else in my family had gone to college in America so I knew that CUNY was more likely what was going to happen, and that's exactly where I ended up going the first time I went to college.

Cynthia Tobar: Where did you go to college and what was your focus?

Kat Stephens: [00:05:21] I started out at City College and I was a double major in musical theatre and journalism. I loved it. I loved every second of it. I stayed for a little while; I think a semester and a half and then I dropped out. I had to work and help my family with certain responsibilities and so that kind of started everything.

[00:05:45] I went to school for a little bit and then I worked. Had a really wonderful career and then hopped in and out of school over like a three year period. Then when I went back to school I went to Borough of Manhattan Community College and I went back for about two or three semesters, in and out, and then I took a break again. Then I finally went back fulltime in 2010.

[00:06:05] I ended up majoring in writing and literature at BMCC and that was like the best experience ever. I had always wanted to go back to school but I had a really wonderful career as a professional makeup artist and business manager in a whole different field altogether. And I had done my career and I had done fashion week and I had done horror makeup and beauty makeup, and every kind of thing you can imagine I had done it.

[00:06:31] I was really bored with that and had a really good run but I wanted to be a thinker and I wanted to be a different kind of thinker so I just went back to school. I quit my job and started school months later. Enrolled in BMCC and that's how I find myself here eight years later.

Cynthia Tobar: What led you from BMCC to Teachers College?

Kat Stephens: [00:06:51] I started at BMCC in September of 2010 and then I went fulltime pretty much. I took winters, I took summers, I took – I didn't take any real

breaks. I was really excited to go back to school. After my first year I started a program at Vassar College called Exploring Transfer and it's like a summer bridge program for community college students across the country.

[00:07:15] I was selected to do this program and you go to Vassar for the summer with like 30 community college students and you take Vassar courses that are [teamtaught] with a Vassar professor and a community college professor. That pretty much changed the trajectory of my entire life. Without that program I don't know what I would have done after the Associates Degree.

[00:07:39] My plan was to go get the Associates and then figure out the rest. I thought maybe I might go to law school but I wasn't quite certain and so once I went to that program after my first year at community college, when I came back to finish my second year I realized that I wanted to pursue teaching, to pursue reading and writing for life, and so that program was a very special moment for me.

Cynthia Tobar: What about the Vassar program ultimately changed your focus from journalism to education?

Kat Stephens: [00:08:08] We were put through our paces. We were prepared. I was prepared for what it would be like if I had transferred to a similar type institution such as Vassar, like a liberal arts, really rigorous school, and so a fully residential program. Everything was paid for. All we had to do was show up and work hard.

[00:08:26] And so it was about five or six weeks in the summer and it was my first time away on a campus living with other students, adjusting to that, adjusting to the dining hall food, adjusting to the deer in Poughkeepsie, adjusting to the – you know we had to read I think 30 books over that six weeks and we had to do a lot of work and it was the best thing that ever happened.

[00:08:50] It prepared me for what happened next, which was when I transferred from BMCC to Sarah Lawrence College, so without that program I mean I don't think I would have been as prepared for all of this that I'm doing right now.

Cynthia Tobar: What kind of relationship did you form with your cohort?

Kat Stephens: [00:09:06] So it had community college students from across the nation, so just 30 of the best students that applied I guess and were chosen to go. So we had community college students from Boston, from Cali, from New Hampshire, from Rhode Island, from New York obviously, from everywhere.

[00:09:25] I laugh about it because at the time we were all sweating and crying and nervous and wanting to throw up and we were community college students that had been told, many of us, that we couldn't succeed, that we weren't able to, that we weren't capable, and so I think for a lot of us it was the first time that we got that affirmation that not only were we capable but we belonged in a place such as Vassar.

[00:09:48] And so many of the people in my cohort are my friends to this day. No matter where we are on the globe we all communicate, we all support each other. Once you're in the cohort you're family for life and so we all support each other to this day. We travel with everything that we do, and that program really gave me the confidence to pursue a certain type of schooling.

Cynthia Tobar: How did your experience at Vassar affect your decision to pursue more education at Sarah Lawrence College?

Kat Stephens: [00:10:16] That process was very daunting. I had, again, been the first person to do that kind of thing. Up until that point all I had known of higher education was CUNY and so that was what I was familiar with. I don't think anyone in my immediate family had ever – well, I know no one has ever gone to any schooling outside of CUNY and so for me that was a big step because if I was going to do it I was going to do it on my own.

[00:10:45] So figuring out how to apply, figuring out the common app, figuring out the CSS report, all of those things, so those moving parts I had to kind of learn on my own. And luckily I had a cohort of students that were also going through the same process and we were all applying to transfer at the same time. And so I just felt like I was unlikely – I was an unlikely candidate and I just said I'll try anyway, and I tried and I lucked up and I got into Sarah Lawrence.

[00:11:13] I remember my mother didn't quite know what Sarah Lawrence was. She knew a little bit but she didn't know enough. And then my other sister knew a lot and so she was screaming on the phone and she was excited and she said, "I don't care. You have to go to Sarah Lawrence. That's a great school" and so that's how it was decided for me that I was going to Sarah Lawrence. And I went and I moved on campus and made the most of it.

[00:11:36] Sarah Lawrence is a very unorthodox place. I think about it fondly. It really helped me to shape myself as a student leader. It really gave me confirmation of what I wanted to do and helped me kind of decide that I wanted to do work that would make a difference in the world.

[00:11:53] What Sarah Lawrence did – they have a really different model and so there is no real majors and you don't have a lot of different concentrations to choose from, and you kind of can chart your own course. For me, especially

as a nontraditional student it was really important to me to have my own say in my own education and to be as selfleading as possible.

[00:12:15] When I was there I loved every minute of it. I studied sociology, Ed policy, Afrikaner studies, women's studies and Caribbean literature, and so it was just the best time and I loved every minute of it. It was difficult. It was hard work but I had done the program at Vassar and that kind of gave me the – that gave me a pep in my step as far as like I know that I can do anything once I'd survived that boot camp.

[00:12:42] And to this day I always think about, well, you did that, you can do this. So now Teachers College doesn't – it's not a daunting thing to get this work done because I know I've done something difficult before and I can do it again.

Cynthia Tobar: What role did your identity play during your time at Sarah Lawrence?

Kat Stephens: [00:12:56] So it's no surprise, it is a PWI; it's a predominantly white institution. I think the biggest thing for me that was different was, one, my age; two, my life experiences and it being a career changer at that point and living on campus as well; and I think thirdly but not last, certainly being a black woman.

[00:13:22] I think that combination of things – it was difficult at moments. There was definitely racial – the climate was – there was a lot happening on the campus climate over the time I was there and so that gave me the fire to really speak up for other students that looked like me.

[00:13:41] We started a whole campaign. Myself and three other students, three other black women, we started a campaign called DOSN, Dangers of a Single Narrative, and we kind of tore things apart at the school for about three years, which was amazing because change needed to happen and change did happen. But it really was a campaign to ask the school to look critically at the way that it [interchanged] itself with curriculum, with hiring practices, with admissions practices, housing, so there was a lot that came out of that.

[00:14:14] It was really hard work but we know that the institution also had students ten or 15 years before us that had done similar things. There were students that came before us and so we felt that – and I felt that it was my responsibility to lead a charge on campus for students that looked like myself.

Cynthia Tobar: What was the impact of your activism at Sarah Lawrence?

Kat Stephens: [00:14:36] There were good and bad impacts, for sure. Some of it was losing sleep; some of it was not knowing if my scholarship would be taken away for speaking up for what I felt like other students needed. Part of it was being

ostracized on campus and not having as much support and people not wanting to associate themselves with you because you were speaking out for social justice issues.

[00:14:56] And the other side of it was people sending you an email or writing something anonymous to give you support and tell you to keep doing the work that you're doing. And then after I graduated seeing that, oh, yeah, they opened a social justice living/learning apartment on campus or, oh yes, they took some of our suggestions for hiring, or maybe after I left there were other students that were able to continue the work.

[00:15:21] And so I think it was last year they brought us back, they invited us back to speak and that was a strange moment because we didn't know if we would graduate because we were speaking out for what we needed, and they brought us back so that was nice.

Cynthia Tobar: Were there supporters of your activism at the administrative level at Sarah Lawrence?

Kat Stephens: [00:15:39] There were two in particular. One would be Dean Green; Dean Al Green is his name. I have to say it just like that. Dean Green was always a really strong, strong supporter of us students asking for what we needed and being able to navigate between the hierarchy of the institution.

[00:15:59] Then I would also say the library archivist, Abby Lester. She was amazing in helping us dig through the school's history, connect us with other alumni, really get us a solid footing so that when we would go to the president's office and have our meetings with her and sit in faculty meetings, we knew what we were talking about and our time was not to be wasted.

[00:16:21] And we gave them that respect and they in turn gave us the same respect. I think we kind of disarmed people by not being a certain type of student that was – maybe they thought would be angry. We were angry but we also knew the limits of the institution and how we would best engage with them to get what we wanted as well, and so that's the route we chose to engage.

Cynthia Tobar: How did your experience at Sarah Lawrence propel you to continue your education at Teachers College?

Kat Stephens: [00:16:47] Once I was ready to graduate from Sarah Lawrence I knew that I'd firmly settled on education as the route for me to go, rather than law school or being a writer in a creative way. I knew that I wanted to do work that happened like maybe outside of the classroom. I didn't quite know what it was yet but I figured I would apply to student affairs programs.

[00:17:13] And so for me I wanted to be an educator outside of the classroom, and funnily now I want to be an educator in the classroom so it's just a number of full circle moments. But I applied to schools and went to a graduate school somewhere else; not TC, and I started in a traditional program and didn't love it. The environment was not a good fit for me and so I decided to transfer to the Teachers College, and that was the best thing I ever did.

Cynthia Tobar: What were your initial impressions of Teachers College and how was it different from your other graduate school?

Kat Stephens: [00:17:48] So when I applied the first time to graduate school I started a TC application and never finished it because I thought like, "That's Columbia, that's Teachers College, I'll never get in," and I kind of took myself through that even though I had already surpassed many other obstacles. So I talked myself out of it and then went onto another graduate school elsewhere.

[00:18:08] And after seeing the kind of – the racialized climate and strife that was going on at the campus that I went to I decided I have to go back home and I have to apply to TC, this is the time. And so I didn't really have another option; I only applied for TC and that was it. I was going to get in or I wasn't going to get in. Luckily I got in and I've been here – this is my third year now at pursuing my EDM.

[00:18:36] This was just what I was looking for. Focus on research, opportunities to network with other students and faculty across the tristate area, opportunities to join a research team and have a curriculum that was, for me, focused on social justice and also more of a researcher side and not as much of a practitioner point of view, which my other program was heavily focused on that and I wanted something more varied.

Cynthia Tobar: What led you to focus on higher and postsecondary education aspects of the field versus other available options?

Kat Stephens: [00:19:08] I came to an open house. I came to the final open house. I remember coming. I had just gotten off a plane from where I was in my other program. Turned in my final exam, got on a plane, came to New York, dropped my suitcases off and got back on the subway and came all the way to Harlem.

[00:19:25] When I got to the open house I just felt the electricity in the air. I felt the presentation that was being given by [Hipsy] faculty and I remember raising my hand when they were talking about the concentric circles and talking about community colleges, and in that moment I felt like I belonged and there was a space for me here.

[00:19:45] So that for me, I was sold and I finished my application and turned it right in and I just knew that – I didn't have a plan B so there was no other option. Luckily, there was no other option.

Cynthia Tobar: What are some memorable courses you've taken at Teachers College?

Kat Stephens: [00:20:00] I think one of my favorite courses was a course that I took with Doctor Dwaine Bruce and the title of the class escapes me right now, but I loved the class because it was really diverse, as most of our classes are; they're diverse. But his curriculum really allowed me to sink my teeth into things that I was interested in.

[00:20:22] I got to write a paper on nontraditional students, nontraditional aged students and their journey from community college to the doctorate. How they are socialized to take that path if they are socialized to take that path, and I think at that moment I was able to see myself as a population in a different kind of way.

[00:20:42] Another course that I loved was [divisional] diversity with Doctor Dresner of course. That course I also got to think a lot about transfer, transition, transition theory and all of the transitions I've been through as a student. It really came home for me in that class. I think so many of the classes I just loved.

Cynthia Tobar: How does your identity affect your experience as a student at TC?

Kat Stephens: [00:21:05] I think that over time my identity has shifted. I think my identity stays the same but I think that what makes you walk from day to day may look different, depending on what's happening, what the environment asks for. And so now I think what I'm definitely standing in is my roots, my understanding of myself as an immigrant woman; an immigrant woman that happens to be black, that happens to be an older student that happens to be a careerchanger. I also happen to be all of these things but I also would say that my immigrant path, my immigrant story, my immigrant roots are as prevalent as ever right now, especially given everything that's going on in this country.

[00:21:54] And so that's something that I come back to time and time again, so being a woman, being a black woman, those are all the things that are incredibly important to me, but I think it's disconnected if I don't talk about being born somewhere else and sometimes also still navigating race in an American context, when I also have a very different context in understanding of race and ethnicity as well.

Cynthia Tobar: How does your race affect your classroom experience at TC? Does it ever feel isolating?

Kat Stephens: [00:22:23] I think there maybe have been like a few times that my race has felt isolated for me as a TC student and I think that may have been earlier in my TC student life where maybe I was like one or two in a class that looked like myself.

[00:22:39] But I think where I am now I use it as a tool to learn, to share and also to engage and listen and learn from other people as well, so I don't think it hinders me in any way. I think sometimes it feels like it's a burden to have to carry and talk about certain things that I feel like other people could do. Sometimes that gets heavy, having to feel like I have to be the representative. I don't want to be the representative. I just want to be me. I don't want to be myself and I don't want to have to speak for everyone, but I also know that sometimes you have to step up.

[00:23:15] I know there have been moments where I felt like I've had to be more of a – it's more of like a model minority in a way of, well, you have to represent yourself well. You have to represent women well. You have to represent black women well. You have to represent immigrant people well.

[00:23:37] And so there comes a point I think, at least for me, there became a point where I knew that performing blackness or performing it in an American context, turning it on and turning it off in different spaces. When I'm with my students across the school that are also immigrants, or come from other places in the Biafra, there is a level of comfort that I don't have to pretend anything. I can just be my full self.

[00:24:05] And then sometimes when I'm with other students that goes away, so I think I'm at a place where I recognize that for me to go forward with my education and to be a scholar and researcher, that my identity has to be full center. Like I cannot perform a certain kind of blackness just to appease and make everyone else more comfortable.

[00:24:26] Like if you don't understand what I'm saying you can ask me what I mean, you can ask me to slow down but I don't think that I should hide my past in order to fit in anywhere, and I think that may have been more of where I started the program. And now I think as I'm reflecting on finishing the program in May I am a proud AfroCaribbean woman and that is where I come to at this point with everything.

Cynthia Tobar: Do you believe faculty and students value diversity at Teachers College?

Kat Stephens: [00:24:55] I think yes and no. I think for the higher Ed program I think absolutely, yes, 100 percent. I think that I'm really fortunate to be in the program that I'm in. I think other people across the school as I've gotten to know other students have not had the same experiences that I've had, and I think that there is work to be done across the university, across the college.

[00:25:17] But I do think that we have a really good solid roadmap in our program; I'm very proud to be a higher Ed student in our program, coming from our school. And I think that what sets the work apart here is that we're not resting on being a Columbia college or a Columbia affiliate. That only gets you so far but what is the work? What are students doing? What is going into the curriculum? What are the faculties doing? How are they supporting you in front of the scenes and behind the scenes as well? And so I think that, for me, I have had nothing but support in every step of my career here.

Cynthia Tobar: What barriers exist that prevent Teachers College from being inclusive to all students?

Kat Stephens: [00:25:59] When I think about it from a student's standpoint and then I think about it from a researcher's standpoint, I think about it from a practitioner's standpoint, I think the things that connect for me would be access and that being a tool to really help people get into a school like this and also remain in a school like this.

[00:26:19] I think there is not enough synergy between programs or departments so that students know what availability they have for opportunities, but also just how people are doing. I think, again, I feel very fortunate to be in the higher Ed program because it is so strongly rooted in social justice, but social justice can look different for every field or discipline.

[00:26:42] And so I think because in higher Ed we look at the institutions, we look at systems of oppression, we talk about this stuff, so I think if other programs have some sort of mandated discussion point for that to happen – I'm not saying that it's not – but I see from peers that they're lacking in certain things in that area.

Cynthia Tobar: How does your race affect your ability to succeed at Teachers College?

Kat Stephens: [00:27:05] I don't know that my race has inhibited anything. I think – and I don't know that it has made anything better either. I'm sort of neutral about race in that aspect. I think more along the lines of ethnicity. I think that that is a sticking point where there could be more work, more knowledge, more education across the institution as far as where people are actually from and how they identify and how they break down. I think that there is nuance there and I don't that we go into the nuance enough.

[00:27:42] And I think that there is a great learning that can be had across the students, across faculty, across staff, but I don't know that I think of race – my race and my understanding of race in this context is still developing even though I've been here, in this country for a long time. It's still developing and it changes because race – if I go home to my country it looks different. Race

when I'm in Little Caribbean, in Brooklyn or Queens looks different. Race when I'm here in Harlem, because we are in Harlem, looks different so I think for me it's more of an ethnicity thing.

[00:28:15] I've just found that I find other students that share similar stories, that share similar understandings, they share similar backgrounds to myself – and it's funny, I don't necessarily consider myself like, oh, I would say I'm an international student but I was born somewhere else and I was raised here, so I think that there could be some kind of fluidity or nuance between programming that's done for international students and maybe broadening that.

[00:28:45] But I think there is work for TC to do in understanding that all students don't – that look the same are not from the same place, are not talking the same language. TC has done a great job but I think there is more work to do just like anything else.

Cynthia Tobar: What are your recollections of your initial involvement with Black Lives Matter in higher education?

Kat Stephens: [00:29:05] I think it was 2016 during the summer or beginning – like late summer I got an email from Doctor Campbell and Doctor Dresner in our program asking if I'd like to be involved in this Black Lives Matter in higher education.

[00:29:23] I think the prior academic year – with like myself I had talked to my advisor, Doctor Dresner, repeatedly about what was going on in the world and how I felt a little frustrated and stifled and wanted to really just do something. I didn't know what I wanted to do.

[00:29:41] So it was a very surprising thing to see that email coming into the fall; fall of 2016 and seeing that they had thought about what I'd even talked about or had thought about what they may have wanted to see or ways to get students involved.

[00:29:57] So it was just a very surprising moment and one that I was really honored and excited to join in and do anything about, and it's definitely surpassed anything that I thought that it might be, but it was a surprise for sure.

Cynthia Tobar: What was the atmosphere on campus like at this time?

Kat Stephens: [00:30:11] That summer in particular was a very hard summer as I remember correctly. I think that was the summer with definitely Philando Castile. I think that was the summer of Alton Sterling I think and I think that was also the summer of [Curran Gaines] untimely – all untimely deaths.

[00:30:30] And so I think I'd been feeling a lot of frustration about black women being left out of the conversation often in the face of police brutality and state violence and I think that I was really frustrated and wanted a space to do something.

[00:30:47] And so coming into my second year at TC the summer there was just so much happening in the world, so much happening in New York that it was just a very sad time, and to be able to come back with hope into the school year – I didn't know what we were going to do. I didn't know how TC would receive students and faculty joining together to do this thing called Black Lives Matter. And so me it's just like, again, surpassed any expectations that I had because I didn't know how this campus culture would acclimate to that idea.

Cynthia Tobar: What did the initial organizing entail and what was it like?

Kat Stephens: [00:31:25] So when we came to the school year myself, Doctor Dresner, Doctor Campbell, another student, Brian Alan and I, we all sat often in Noah's office and just talked about what could this look like? What we wanted it to be. What is our intention? What is our goal? What would a wild dream be?

[00:31:49] After we started to do that I know Brian brought on Shar I believe, [Shar McNeil], and she also came in and Brian and I had worked on a research project for Doctor Bruce prior, so we had already been acquainted through that. And so it was just like the more the merrier; let's see what we can do.

[00:32:09] So I had never done something that explicit such as Black Lives Matter in higher education, and I think I thought at moments like are they going to let us do this? Is this OK? We have their support but do we really have their support? And so there were a few moments where I'm thinking, wow, is TC ready for this? This might seem a little too radical but it all worked out.

[00:32:35] I think a lot of it – like we met often in Noah's office and we would go through what we wanted to talk about [unintelligible]. I know that I wanted to talk a lot about identity. I wanted to talk about the formation of ethnic identity among people that identify as black across the board and I wanted to talk about police brutality. I wanted to talk about the psychological state of students and what they would be going through on campuses as they were dealing with all of these different racial strifes across the country.

[00:33:07] I also wanted to talk about women in higher education, black women in higher education and how they navigate the spaces, so I think for me identity always came up as who I am comes into the work. But we then really had to formalize and think, well, who do we know? Who can we invite

and what kind of programming can we put together to really support getting the message across.

[00:33:30] And the question of Black Lives Matter in higher education and does it matter in higher education and how does it matter in higher education? How do we know that it matters? Do we see that money follows? Do we see that admission follows? Do we see that more faculty hires follow? How can we look at black lives mattering across the board, but also in TC because this is where we all live?

Cynthia Tobar: How has your vision of activism in higher education changed since beginning your work with Black Lives Matter at TC?

Kat Stephens: [00:33:55] It's so different. I think, again, when I was at BMCC my activism was like baby activism then and it was about getting funding for student newspapers and getting to print what we wanted to print and put out what we wanted to put out that would have been critical of BMCC. That was really difficult there.

[00:34:17] Then I think about going to Sarah Lawrence and starting DOSN with three other women, all who were either African women or AfroCaribbean women and we started this together, and thinking how do we push back against that institution? That was a little more difficult as well. We did have buyin in the end but we did not have that kind of support that we'd have here at Teachers College with Black Lives Matter for higher Ed.

[00:34:45] And so here we were welcome and we were seen as people to coconspire with. There wasn't a hierarchy of, oh, we're faculty and we know what's best and you're going to do this thing for us; it was let's all get together, we care about this environment, we want to see each other and have a room and a space to create something, and so that's what we did.

[00:35:07] And so there wasn't pushback in a certain way. It was let's think of something and see if it sticks, and the first year's programming was just wild. I can't even think of – I didn't know any of that was going to happen, that people show up. People came to our events.

[00:35:26] We had an event that focused on black activism, student activism across campuses. We looked at the situation at the University of Missouri that had taken place. We had an event that looked at mental health and black lives mattering in higher education. That was collaboration with counseling psyche and clinical psyche programs at Teachers College as well with some of their students, and Doctor [Daryl Su] came to that as well.

[00:35:53] We had [DeRay Mekasin] – I'm probably saying his name wrong so I apologize, but he came as well with Doctor Charles F. Davis from USC

Rossier. They came and spoke about the action – actual work, excuse me – of activists that are going on right now within Black Lives Matter. That would probably close out the year as well.

[00:36:19] Starting this year we had Doctor Chrystal George Mwangi from UMass Amherst come and help us to talk about black lives mattering but across the diaspora and what that looks like as far as identity for our students, so we've had rich programming.

Cynthia Tobar: How has your participation in programming followed your own development from a student to a practitioner at TC?

Kat Stephens: [00:36:40] I think knowing that when we took a break for the summer and we were coming back into fall of 2017 I personally wanted to start at the beginning, and for me the beginning looked like how can we even identify what is black lives in Black Lives Matter if we don't know who the black lives are?

[00:36:58] And so for me, as someone who has had training in sociology and being a Caribbeanist, that goes through all of the work that I do. If I really wanted to be able to – like let's talk about and break down who is actually black and who are we actually talking to because not everyone's blackness is the same.

[00:37:17] Blackness is not a monolith and so everyone's blackness looks different and so I think if we think about the diaspora, knowing that students come here from all over the world, we really should be thinking about what peoples' identities are and how they see themselves, how they interface with race and ethnicity.

[00:37:35] And before we can even go any further into thinking about does Black Lives Matter, who is in our universities? Who is here? Who is being admitted? Who is not being admitted? How does this impact the bottom line for universities? So I think for me, because I care so much about access, that's my starting point always. Who is actually here and what do they call home?

Cynthia Tobar: What are your plans moving forward based on that theme?

Kat Stephens: [00:38:01] So right now I am hoping to start a PhD program in the fall, so still waiting to hear from all of the schools, the many schools. And for my work and what I hope to be my life's work, to think about black women in the diaspora, particularly those that are Caribbean, AfroCaribbean women and how they navigate norms within their cultural understandings of education, cultural understandings of educational attainment and also family and culture.

[00:38:32] And so for me I want to be able to focus on women that have these experiences because it is different, but there are things that are the same but there are things that are also very different. And so I know for a lot of students they often feel very silenced and so I want to give them a voice.

Cynthia Tobar: What do you see as the future of Black Lives Matter at TC and how will you be involved going forward?

Kat Stephens: [00:38:53] We are so fortunate. We have a great number of students that started, this cohort that came in the fall of 2017, and they jumped right in and they are also part of the planning committee now. We meet on Sundays and we sketch things out and everyone has a part that they play and they pick something that they want to do and attack that part of the process.

[00:39:15] And so we have students that will be here for the year or two years, maybe even three years that are doing the work and also will take over, you know, if and when we leave, how we leave this space. Something I imagine, if I don't stay at TC to continue doctoral work, I would hope to still be some kind of affiliate and do some kind of work wherever I end up going and maybe starting a chapter of it at that campus, wherever I go. I think the issue is going to remain the same regardless. I think the institution might look different but I still want to do the work wherever I go.

Cynthia Tobar: What overarching goal do you have and how does a degree from Teachers College help you accomplish it?

Kat Stephens: [00:39:51] I think it helps in every way. I think there is that thing of, you know that shiny sticker of people hear and think and bring up lots of ideas about whatever Columbia means to them, and whatever Teachers College means to them as well. I feel like I'm very fortunate to go to a school where Teachers College means something and Columbia University means something.

[00:40:10] And so I know that people understand what kind of training I would have had up until this point; that speaks for itself. But also the support that I've had from faculty here and the support that I've had from administrators here and staff, I feel like it primed me to really do whatever I want to do going forward, including this programming that has allowed me to really reconcile my identity in a way where I'm confident in whatever I go on next.

[00:40:41] That it is OK to study what I want to study and not have to think about, well, maybe I can only study this kind of blackness or this kind of blackness, like I think I have a duty to stay honest to what I want to study and this program and this work has given me a great license to do that going forward. So I'm going to study women that look like me, I'm going to study

the richness and vastness of the diaspora but I'm going to study people in the islands because one island is not the whole island and so there's difference even in that.

Cynthia Tobar: What are your individual strengths and talents and how do you use them to achieve your goals?

Kat Stephens: [00:41:14] I love social media and so a way that that's shown up with Black Lives Matter has been we've created Tshirts and we've created stickers with our logo on them and we have started campaigns. We have a Twitter account. We have an Instagram account. We have gone to Naspers with our shirts to the national conferences, to the regional conference, and people across the country and the globe have been ordering Black Lives Matter Columbia Teachers College swag, so that has been mind-blowing to see.

[00:41:47] Like OK, we really need to produce something that people can touch and get and wear and to see people doing the work, showing up at professional conferences in our swag. A great sense of pride for me to see that people want the gear, are wearing it and it means something to them. That even if they're not here the message is still being spread.

Cynthia Tobar: What obstacles have you encountered and how have you overcome them?

Kat Stephens: [00:42:12] The biggest thing I'd probably say is for as much as I know how institutions work, as much as I understand hierarchy and power and people in positions, as much as I understand how to code switch in a way there are still moments where I have gotten frustrated. There are still moments where institutions feel like these mammoth things that you cannot break through. There are still moments where I feel like is this all worth it? Why am I doing this? Why don't I just go back and get a simple job and do something instead of trying to change the world because that feels like, why me? Why am I doing this work?

[00:42:52] So I think at times I do get frustrated with that and it feels like there is no way I can make any difference here. But I do know that if not for this, if not for other programs, I wouldn't be where I am now so I have to continue to do the work for other people that I don't even know their names yet. So I think the biggest obstacle would be finding a way to survive as a student.

[00:43:14] Finding a way to pay my bills as a student. Finding a way to juggle three or four jobs as a student and still keep a high GPA and still present at conferences and work on research and writing my IP and trying to graduate. You know, these are all things that nobody talks about because you're just expected to perform, and sometimes I think that in performing we lose the humanity and who we are because we're just so used to doing.

[00:43:45] I think that works up until a certain degree but I don't know that it's the most healthy socialization for graduate students, and so I think about that a lot and that may show up in future work.

Cynthia Tobar: How are you able to balance and sustain your obligations effectively?

Kat Stephens: [00:43:58] This being my third year at TC I have done it and I don't know how I've done it, but I do know that community is important. I do know that I have my grad mates; I have my grad friends in the program. I feel very connected to people across my time that I've been here.

[00:44:14] I also have undergraduate roommates that are here at TC now and also studying, so I have people that I know for some years now. And I have family and if I get, you know, bogged down with this I'll get on the Long Island railroad and go to Queens and hang out for a day or two and then I'll come back to campus.

[00:44:35] But I think keeping organized is difficult but I also know that I've been maybe a professional student for some time now so I feel like this is the best space for me to be me. I'm more comfortable with it than probably having a nine to five, like this is for me the life that I'm choosing and this is what I feel comfortable doing even though it gets difficult.

Cynthia Tobar: Who are the key people in your life who have played a strong role in your educational journey?

Kat Stephens: [00:45:01] I think – something I think right now what I am comfortable with, what I see myself as is an emerging or learning young junior scholar activist, and that is what I think I will end up seeing myself doing. It has to be both for me. I don't know that at that point I can divorce one and keep the other.

[00:45:24] I think that while I have done practitioner work in the past, and I loved the work that I've done in admissions and recruitment, that work is near and dear to me. I don't think that I will do that for the rest of my life. I think I'm meant to be a faculty member and be in front, engaging with students, so I think that for me, that part of myself while also being an activist have to go hand in hand. There is not one without the other at this point.

Cynthia Tobar: Who are the key people in your life who have played a strong role in your educational journey?

Kat Stephens: [00:45:54] I think about my nieces and nephews. They're younger obviously, they're the next generation in my family and I think about them, and I think about – even if they don't see it, even if they don't put the dots together. You know, there was a moment I had with one of my nieces and she asked me I

think last year maybe, you know, do I have my doctorate? I think she was 12 at the time and she asked me, “Do you have your doctorate?” When I was 12 I didn’t ask anyone that question and I said, “No, I don’t have it yet but I will.” She said, “Oh, OK, because that’s cool. I know other people with a doctorate and my aunty is going to have hers one day.”

[00:46:34] You know, I think about things like that sometimes. I try not to think about it too much because it adds a little bit of pressure to me, which I have a lot on me already, but I think about them and I think about the past. I think about my grandparents. I think about my great grandparents. I think about the indentured servants that were my great grandparents. I think about them travelling all over the world and being brought involuntarily and dropped wherever they were on the globe, and that for me sustains me in not giving up.

[00:47:05] And I think, of course, like my advisor. My advisor, Doctor Dresner, is the best advisor and I will say that forever. He is the best advisor, and my community college advisors still are in touch with me today. They still [write] me today and I think about a moment that I had in a class at community college was a professor that told me that, you know, you’re going to be a faculty member one day. You’re going to be a great teacher. I never saw that for myself but he said it and now I believe it. So Doctor [Faisec], that’s him and, yeah, I feel very grateful to have a community of people across the way.

Cynthia Tobar: How has your work with Black Lives Matter in higher education changed the way you engage in activism in your community?

Kat Stephens: [00:47:47] I think, if anything, it sharpened it for me. It’s sharpened my focus on women and knowing that I want to do work that impacts women. I think about women that have stopped their education for a myriad of reasons. I think about women that have gotten the short end of the stick and are bright and have tons to offer, but for whatever reason were not able to get that certification on paper that they needed.

[00:48:10] And so how can I then help them to get this formal education so that they can feed their families and take care of themselves and be selfsufficient. I think about the ways in which women are perpetually harmed in society and left out to pasture, in a sense sometimes, because of anything that may have happened.

[00:48:30] Failed relationships or failed – or just bad luck, and I think that sometimes we [assess] that women can do everything because we can, but I think that there needs to be a focus in higher Ed on women in the diaspora that are speaking different stories and have different narratives and helping them navigate an American system while still navigating their home systems as

well and their home norms. So I think about that becoming more finite and more narrow as I go along.

Cynthia Tobar: It's the 50th anniversary of the Columbia student revolt on 1968. What are your thoughts about student activism's continued influence on culture and politics?

Kat Stephens: [00:49:04] Sure, I think about a show like "Grownish" on TV, for example, and a show like "A Different World" and I think about those two shows in particular being so far apart in years, but also still having a thread in them of students in these bodies, in those spaces that are revolutionary and are not always seen as the norm.

[00:49:24] And I think that it creates a space where, yes, students of color are in schools, they are going to college and they are at faster rates than ever before. I think it's just normal now and I think pop culture has done a lot for that. That going to school is a thing to do and is not a bad thing to do. It's a great thing to do.

Cynthia Tobar: How would you characterize the impact of all the work you've done on your own life and your own thinking?

Kat Stephens: [00:49:49] I think that it's probably given me a little more confidence as far as knowing what I'm about and having conviction within that. I know that whatever my impulse is, whatever my gut is, to go with my gut, to stick with that and I cannot produce scholarship or I cannot produce ideas that don't come from an authentic place for me.

[00:50:12] I think that it's helped me to just recognize and stand firm in who I am and know that I'm not going to be able to tell a story the way that any other student is. I can only tell it my way from where I've been in the world. And so for me that is probably the turning point where I'm at now; that anything I do going forward has to be because it's authentic and because I love it and not because I think it will make a great journal article or it will be a trendy thing to talk about. I must do work that I believe in.

[End of recorded material 00:50:45]